

ADVANCING FIRST CLASS PRE-K IN ALABAMA

Who Leaves? Experience, Credentials, and Early-Career Risk in the Pre-K Workforce

Turnover differences among lead and auxiliary teachers, 2021–22 to 2025–26

JoonHo Lee and Alison Hooper ■ August 2026

The companion brief in this series showed that about one in five First Class Pre-K teachers leaves the program each year and that half of a cohort is gone within three, and we examine here who those leavers are. Using the same 11,651 teacher-year transitions from the program’s rosters (2021–22 through 2025–26), we break turnover down by experience, credential, role, and site size. Departures are not spread evenly across the workforce. They concentrate at the start of careers, where more than one in four teachers with two or fewer years of experience leaves the program in a given year, and among teachers working under credential waivers, whose exit rate is roughly double that of teachers with degrees.

We highlight four patterns:

- **Experience.** Less experience is associated with higher rates of departure: teachers with 0–2 years of experience left the program at 27.9 percent a year, versus 16–17 percent for every band above 5 years, and changed sites at 34.2 percent (figure 1).
- **Credentials.** Teaching under a credential waiver is associated with the highest exit rate we observe, at 32.8 percent a year, against 15.5–19.9 percent for teachers with degrees or credential coursework (figure 2).

- **Role.** Auxiliary teachers left the program at 22.1 percent a year and lead teachers at 17.6 percent, a gap that compounds into the classroom’s day-to-day staffing.
- **Site size.** Teachers who are the only First Class teacher at their site left the program at 21.3 percent, the highest rate of any site-size group (table 1).

As throughout this series, these are descriptive counts from the roster census, and “leaving the program” means absence from the next year’s First Class Pre-K rosters rather than necessarily leaving teaching.

The Profile of Leavers and Retention Policy

Although an overall turnover rate indicates how large the replacement problem is, the profile of who leaves indicates what kind of problem it is and where retention resources would most plausibly matter. Departures concentrated among new teachers point toward induction and mentoring, departures concentrated among waiver-credential teachers point toward credential pathways, and higher churn among auxiliary teachers and solo teachers points toward working conditions and staffing structure. The patterns we report below are intended to give Alabama’s retention conversation that resolution.

In this brief, the seventh in the *Advancing First Class Pre-K in Alabama* series, we extend the turnover baseline established in brief 6 (Lee and Hooper 2026); a companion brief examines the pay and benefits structures that sit alongside these patterns.

BOX 1

Data and Methods

Data. We use First Class Pre-K staff rosters for 2021–22 through 2025–26, linked into 11,651 teacher-year transitions among 5,235 resolved identities (see brief 6 for the identity-resolution method). Experience bands reflect reported years of experience, and credential groups reflect the highest reported credential in the transition year. A “waiver” marks teachers approved to teach while a credential requirement is temporarily waived.

Measures. We treat a teacher as having “left the program” when she is absent from the next year’s rosters, whereas “left their site” additionally counts moves between First Class sites. Rates pool the four observed transitions, and all published groups contain at least 71 transitions. Our results describe the roster census and support no causal claims.

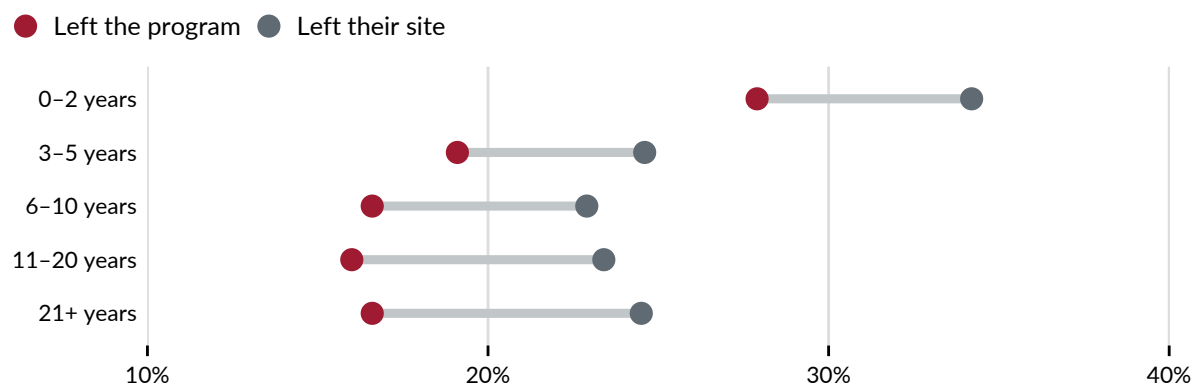
Departures by Years of Experience

Less experience is associated with higher rates of departure, and experience is the sharpest dividing line we observe in these data (figure 1). Teachers in their first two years left the program at 27.9 percent a year, whereas by 3–5 years of experience the rate drops to 19.1 percent, and from 6 years on it flattens near 16–17 percent. Site-change rates follow the same staircase, falling from 34.2 percent to about 23–25 percent.

FIGURE 1

The First Two Years Carry the Highest Departure Risk

Share of teachers leaving, by years of experience, pooled 2021–22 to 2025–26



Source: Authors' analysis of ADECE First Class Pre-K staff rosters, 2021–22 to 2025–26.

Notes: ADECE = Alabama Department of Early Childhood Education. Lead and auxiliary teachers; experience bands contain 1,259–2,912 transitions each. “Left the program” means absent from the next year’s rosters; “left their site” additionally includes moves between sites.

The shape of that profile matters for policy design: because the risk is front-loaded, retention effort aimed at the first three years would reach teachers at the point when they are most likely to leave, whereas the same resources spread across the whole workforce would mostly reach teachers who were staying in any case. The flat profile after year five also suggests that Alabama does not face a late-career exodus, since once teachers settle they stay at similar rates regardless of tenure.

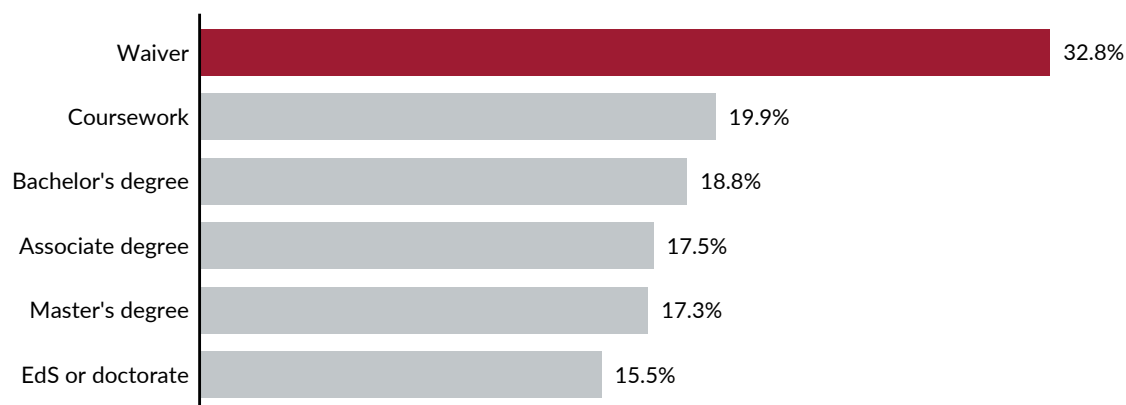
Departures by Credential

Credential status is associated with departure almost as strongly as experience is (figure 2). Teachers working under a credential waiver left the program at 32.8 percent a year, while every other group sits between 15.5 and 19.9 percent: master’s holders at 17.3 percent, bachelor’s at 18.8, associate at 17.5, credential coursework at 19.9, and teachers with EdS or doctoral degrees lowest at 15.5.

FIGURE 2

Waiver Teachers Exit at Nearly Double the Rate of Degree Holders

Share of teachers leaving the program, by highest credential, pooled 2021–22 to 2025–26



Source: Authors' analysis of ADECE First Class Pre-K staff rosters, 2021–22 to 2025–26.

Notes: Credential groups contain 71–4,282 transitions (EdS and doctoral degrees are combined). A waiver marks teachers approved to teach while a credential requirement is temporarily waived.

The waiver group is sizable—799 transitions, or about 7 percent of all observed transitions—and it churns fast enough that the waiver route, as currently experienced, may function less like an on-ramp into the profession than a revolving door. Yet these data cannot say whether that pattern reflects the credential requirement itself, the compensation attached to waiver status, or selection into who takes waiver positions. What they do establish is that the group in which the credential pipeline should be filling is the group draining fastest.

Departures by Role and Site Size

Two quieter patterns complete the profile. Auxiliary teachers left the program at 22.1 percent a year, against 17.6 percent for lead teachers, so the adult a child is more likely to lose is the second one in the room—the role designed to keep ratios small and attention individual. Teachers who are their site's only First Class teacher left at 21.3 percent, the highest of any site-size group (table 1), and when they go the site's whole program experience goes with them.

TABLE 1

Solo-Teacher Sites See the Most Departures

Share of teachers leaving, by number of First Class teachers at the site, pooled 2021–22 to 2025–26

Teachers at site	Transitions	Left the program	Left their site
1 (solo)	3,537	21.3%	28.7%
2	3,894	19.1%	26.2%
3–4	2,579	19.2%	24.2%
5 or more	1,635	19.4%	25.4%

Source: Authors' analysis of ADECE First Class Pre-K staff rosters, 2021–22 to 2025–26.

Notes: Site size counts lead and auxiliary First Class Pre-K teachers on the same year's roster; 6 of the 11,651 transitions lack a site-size value and are omitted.

Discussion

The pattern across these groups suggests that retention effort could be front-loaded where the risk itself is front-loaded. A mentoring and induction commitment concentrated in teachers' first three years would address the single largest block of departures, the 27.9 percent annual exit among 0–2-year teachers, rather than diluting effort across colleagues who statistically were staying in any case.

The waiver route may also be better treated as a pipeline to complete than as a stopgap to tolerate. Pairing waiver status with a funded, time-bound credential pathway, including coursework support, testing fees, and release time, would target the group with the system's highest exit rate, although these data cannot say how much of that 33 percent rate would follow a teacher who completes a credential, since waiver status and early-career status overlap.

Auxiliary teachers belong in the retention conversation as well, because their churn is higher, their role is the classroom's ratio buffer, and they are half the workforce, so retention policies designed only around lead teachers would miss the half of the room that turns over fastest.

Solo sites, finally, may need a connection strategy of their own. Although one-teacher sites cannot offer peer support on site, pairing their teachers into regional networks or coaching cohorts is the available substitute, and those sites' higher exit rate suggests that the isolation is not costless.

Limitations

These analyses have several limitations. The group differences we report are descriptive rather than causal, because new teachers, waiver teachers, and auxiliary teachers differ in many ways these comparisons do not hold constant, and nothing reported here estimates the effect of experience, credentials, or role on leaving. The groups also overlap, since many waiver teachers are also early-career, so the profile identifies where risk concentrates rather than independent contributions. "Leaving" is

program-specific, in that exits include moves to K–12 and other early-childhood settings that these data cannot separate. Finally, credential records reflect what appears on the rosters, and reported credentials may therefore lag actual completion.

The overall message, though, does not appear fragile: Alabama’s pre-K turnover is disproportionately concentrated among teachers in their first years, teachers on waivers, auxiliary teachers, and teachers at solo sites, which are four identifiable places where retention policy can aim.

References

Lee, JoonHo, and Alison Hooper. 2026. “Who Stays? Four Years of Teacher Turnover in First Class Pre-K.” Advancing First Class Pre-K in Alabama, Brief 6. Tuscaloosa: University of Alabama, College of Education.

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ABOUT THIS PROJECT

The Advancing First Class Pre-K in Alabama project examines First Class Pre-K funding, implementation, access, and comparisons with other state pre-K programs. Its goal is to offer recommendations for expanding First Class Pre-K while maintaining high levels of quality.

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